

Physician Coding Starter Pack

GitHub for Physicians Quickstart

The simplest way for doctors to start using version control and project repositories

Series 2 of 3

Clear promise: A beginner-friendly explanation of GitHub for physicians who want to store projects, publish code, and collaborate more confidently.

Part of the Doctors Who Code lead magnet series for physician-builders.

Guide 2 of 3

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What GitHub is

GitHub is a platform for storing and managing projects, especially code-based projects. At its core, it helps you keep versions of your work over time. That means you can track changes, experiment safely, and collaborate without losing the thread of what you built.

For physicians, GitHub can hold website code, app prototypes, slide resources, educational tools, documentation, and structured notes about projects in progress. It is also one of the clearest ways to show that you are building, not just commenting on medical technology.

What a repository does

A repository is the working home for a project. It stores files, preserves history, and gives the project an address. When you work in a repository, you are not just saving a folder. You are building a trackable record of decisions.

That matters because software is iterative. Repositories make it possible to test changes, back up, collaborate, and publish with less fear.

The difference between Git and GitHub

Git is the version control system. GitHub is the online platform that hosts Git repositories and adds collaboration features. Git tracks the history. GitHub gives that history a workspace, interface, and social layer.

You can learn them gradually. You do not need to internalize every command before starting.

Terms worth learning early

- Repository: a project folder that contains files and version history.
- Commit: a saved checkpoint of changes.
- Branch: a separate line of development, often used for experimentation.
- Pull request: a proposed set of changes to be reviewed before merging.
- README: the front door of the repository, explaining what the project is and how it works.

Creating your first repository

A good first repository is small and concrete. Name it clearly. Add a README. Put one simple project inside it. The point is not to impress anyone. The point is to make your work legible to your future self and understandable to others.

Consistency matters more than complexity. A few clean repositories will teach you more than one giant idea that never reaches version one.

A good first physician GitHub project

Build a small static website, a checklist app, a calculator based on a clinical guideline, or a curated educational resource page for a topic you know well. Projects like these are realistic, visible, and useful.

GitHub rewards finished work. Start with something you can actually ship.

Common mistakes beginners make

- Starting with a project too large to finish.
- Avoiding GitHub until the project feels perfect.
- Treating version control as advanced rather than foundational.
- Leaving repositories undocumented.
- Confusing public visibility with readiness. Early work can be simple and still be worth sharing.